

Contra.



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MAY 20TH, 2022



BLUE PRAWN

Blue Prawn | Turnip | Perilla Leaves
Pineapple Guava | Etrog | Yuba and Umeboshi Emulsion

SCALLOP

Scallop Crudo | Kohlrabi | Seaweed | Asian Pear

LOBSTER TART

Lobster Tail | Lobster Sauce with Rose | Lobster and Scallop Mousse | Chanterelle

MONKFISH

Monkfish | Koginut Squash Broth | Maitake | Swiss Chard Dumpling

BLACKBERRY & PISTACHIO

Blackberry Semifredo | Pistachio Mousse | Olive Oil Cake | Sorrel | Crunchy Sablé

STRAWBERRY & ALMOND

Almond Mousse | Strawberry Granita | Fresh and Dried Strawberry



SCALLOP

Following the raw blue prawn is another seafood crudo dish. The scallop here is counterpointed by Asian pears, seaweed, and kohlrabi. The Asian pear tastes like an alien component in the melange, not only because of its scarcity of acidity but also for the harsh texture that fails to match other components. Slices of granny smith should work better in this case. The choice of the cut of the scallop may also matter. Considering the fact that all the other ingredients are presented in slices, the overall flavor and palate could be more united if the scallop is cut to medallions. Otherwise, this dish tastes refreshing and natural. The oceanic umami and pristine sweetness of the scallop burst out when engaging with the duo of seaweed and kohlrabi.

BLUE PRAWN

One of the classic dishes on Contra's menu is this creation of blue prawn, featuring blue prawns engulfed in a tropical and oriental medley of turnip, shiso, pineapple guava, and etrog layering above a thin swarp of yuba and umeboshi emulsion. The slightly bitter yet refreshing turnip and aromatic herbal shiso introduced a Japanese touch to the medley, while the pineapple guava and etrog bring in layers of tropical citrusy palate. All the vegetables, herbs, and fruits here work like the Morandi color palette, they are light and refreshing that won't steal the spotlight of the prawn but rather provide varieties of flavors and textures in the background. The yuba and umeboshi emulsion correspond with the Japanese and pristine touch of other ingredients, it counters the whole texture profile with its silkiness yet keeps delivering the lightness of the whole.





LOBSTER TART

The first main course we pick from the menu is a lobster tart. The elastic chunks of lobster tail meat are embedded in a creamy lobster scallop mousse, nestling in the crunchy tart with a layer of thinly sliced chanterelle mushroom and showered by a rich lobster rose sauce made from lobster's head. The lobster rose sauce resembles lobster bisque yet with far richer umami of lobster's head. The crowning touch of rose not only scents the sauce with an alluring euphoric floral perfume but gives the sauce another layer of texture as well. The mousse and lobster tail provides variations of texture and oceanic flavor that distinguish them from the head sauce. The underlying chanterelle adds the final version of earthy umami to the melange, while the tart counters the creaminess of sauce and mousse with its crunchiness.

MONKFISH

The second main course features two pieces of monkfish wrapped in spinach and poached in a butter emulsion, paired with grilled maitake and a swiss chard dumpling, and finished with a koginut squash broth. The lightly butter-poached monkfish shows a perfect gradient of doneness that is delicately firm and elastic at the outer layer yet raw and silky in the center, thus the flesh exhibits a combination of both raw freshness and a rich buttery creaminess and aroma. The dumpling filled with maitake, red Kuri squash, and pepitas (pumpkin seeds) could be too mushy on the mouth as both the swiss chard wrap and the squash filling are swampy that even the pepitas can't save the whole. The Koginut squash broth enriched with black garlic and pepitas carries an oriental temperament.





STRAWBERRY & ALMOND

The first dessert is so impressive that we decide to give the other dessert a try as well. The first dessert blows our mind with its ingenious combination of blackberry and pistachio, yet the second dessert satisfies us with its fine texture and equilibrium of flavors. The marriage of strawberries and almonds is not uncommon, thus it is even harder to impress any epicurean. The velvety almond mousse with delicate snow of strawberry granita exhibits such finesse of texture and flavor. The additional fresh and dried strawberry sublimated the whole with their contrasting textures to the mouse and granite.

BLACKBERRY & PISTACHIO

The first dessert we ordered shows a unique and fabulous interpretation of blackberry and pistachio. The blackberry semifreddo and pistachio mousse showcase smoothness and creaminess with similar yet altered textures. Small pieces of blackberry flesh are scattered in the semifreddo. The explosive fresh blackberry and its crispy seeds invokes dimensions of textures in the semifreddo. The mild flavors of blackberry and pistachio mingle with sorrel and blackberry jus to create a harmonic flavor profile. Underneath the semifreddo and mousse hide a soft and airy olive oil cake and a layer of sweet crunchy sablé that balance out all the other creamy and watery textures.

